DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

# How Does Hardship Serve the Final Tikkun?

Daat Tevunot §54-56

**Sefer:** Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §54-56 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 8 December 2022

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

## Where we are: the time of concealment

The class opens with a review. We are in the part of the book that describes the period in which God's unity, the Yihud Hashem, is concealed. HaKadosh Barukh Hu is always present and always working in the background, but He holds back the revelation of Himself.

The Rabbi reminds us that there are two levels of holding back. The first is that God created us as human beings at all, with a limited ability to grasp Him. The second is that even within what a human being could grasp, He hides Himself further, so that we have free choice and everything that follows from it. Within all of this, in the background, God is steering the world towards the tikkun haklali, the final and complete rectification.

## The paradox of what is hidden and what is seen

The Rabbi sets out the two modes again:

- **Hanhagat hamishpat (the mode of justice).** God runs the world through a system of consequences. He has to reward and punish according to the rules He made. This mode comes from God's concealment: He steps back, as it were, and lets the system run.
- **Hanhagat hayihud (the mode of unity).** God is in complete control and takes full ownership of everything. This mode comes from God not concealing Himself at all.

The paradox is that the mode that comes from concealment is the one we can see, and the mode that comes from openness is the one hidden from us. We see consequences every day. If you cross the street without looking and a car comes, you can be killed. That is reality, and that is the Middat HaMishpat. The Middat HaYihud says that God is master even of those laws, and a car can hit you and nothing happens. That mode runs constantly, but only in the background, and we believe in it rather than see it.

At the end of the discussion one of the participants put it in two sentences, and the Rabbi approved: the concealed part of God's light allows for justice, and that is the part we live with and see; the unconcealed part, where God is not withholding Himself at all, is the part that is hidden from us in this world.

## The child and the road

To make the two modes concrete, the Rabbi returned to an analogy he has used before. You tell a child to look before crossing the road, and warn him that next time he crosses without looking he will be smacked. The child does it again. Justice says: I made a rule, there is a consequence, so I have to carry it out. Unity says: I am the one who made the rule. I see the child smiling, and I cannot bring myself to smack him. The rules of the house are the revealed part. The father's freedom over his own rules is the part that stays in the background.

A participant added that every move we make is absorbed into God's master plan, like a chess game in which no move of ours can bring about an ending other than the one He intends. The Rabbi agreed for the tikkun haklali, but warned that this is "a dangerous thing to say" if it is applied to the personal level. On the personal plane each of us has free choice. On the universal plane God's plan will be completed. "Somehow they get together. I don't know how, but somehow they get together."

## §54: every bad thing serves the whole

The Ramhal now says that in the end God will reveal how all the bad that happened was not only for the good of the individual but for the complete rectification of the universe.

The Rabbi stressed that this is a different point from the familiar one. That something painful in your own life was ultimately for your own good, we have learned already. "This is simple." Here the Ramhal goes further: the things that happened to you were also part of the tikkun of the whole world. God never pushes a person away with both hands. He refines us like metal in a crucible, so that we come out pure. That is always the overriding principle.

Asked whether "the universe" means the Jewish people or mankind, the Rabbi answered that the Ramhal says "briyotav", His creatures, and means all of existence. When the world is rectified it is not only human beings but the whole universe, which was damaged by the sin of Adam, that is restored.

## §55: the surface and the depth

The Ramhal quotes Tehillim: "How great are Your deeds, Hashem, Your thoughts are very deep." God's works have great depth and breadth. What we see now is only the surface. The inner meaning is hidden. Things seem simply bad, but in the world to come we will see how they were part of the tikkun.

The Rabbi gave two warnings here. First, again, this is not about how bad things in your own life turn out well. It is about how each thing adds to the tikkun haklali. Second, do not think that when the end comes you will understand God's ways completely. "You're only going to understand a drop from the sea." Even the full picture at the end will be only a fraction of what was really happening.

On the prophet's words "the eyes of the blind will be opened", the Rabbi explained that "eyes" here means insight, not eyesight, and compared it to the verse about Havah seeing that the tree was desirable to the eyes. When our eyes are opened, we will see from within the events themselves how everything came together.

## §56: the Ramhal's own summary

The Rabbi asked for a summary and then read the Ramhal's. God's perfection itself is never understood. Because He wanted to act with His creatures according to their level, He set up a system of counsels and turns of events to bring all of them to their perfection. That is what is hidden in all His works. Part of this hidden plan will be revealed when He opens our eyes, but most of it remains beyond us, because of the greatness of His wisdom.

The Rabbi tied this back to the two levels of withholding. At the end, one level is removed: we will reach our full potential as human beings and understand how the world functions. The other level is never removed: we will never understand God Himself. And even the functioning we will grasp only in the part that concerns us.

He gave a closing analogy. A large company has a chief executive and many departments. He makes tough decisions about you, and at the end of the year you understand why they were right for your section and your job. But you still do not see how all the departments fit together, and you certainly do not know the chief executive himself.

## Summary

- The mode of justice comes from God's concealment, yet it is the mode we see. The mode of unity comes from His openness, yet it is hidden from us.
- On the personal level we have free choice; on the universal level God's plan for the tikkun haklali will certainly be completed.
- §54: in the end we will see that every hardship served not only our personal good but the rectification of the whole universe.
- §55: what we see now is the surface. Even at the end we will understand only "a drop from the sea".
- §56: God's essence is never understood. Part of His hidden plan will be revealed to us, but most of it stays beyond our reach.

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